

Observing the enterprising spirit of African Americans via basketball

"I Believe I Can Fly" was written by R. Kelly for Space Jam, a popular 1996 movie starring Michael Jordan and other NBA stars in a world of cartoons. In the movie, the song plays in the scene where the young Jordan is practicing late at night and he talks about grand aspirations when his father brings him inside. The movie was a big success at the box office but this song was even bigger, it becomes an inspirational anthem.¹

On the first listen, I perceive that this song is filled with sincere affection and it is a remedy to soothe us in the face of setbacks even if its rhythm is soft. It solidifies the belief that we can overcome challenges through our brave efforts. The positive depiction from the lyrics paints a wonderful picture after realizing our dreams and it reminds us to believe in ourselves and persist until victory comes.

NBA (National Basketball Association) is considered as the premier professional basketball league in the world and we appreciate black players' agile movements and excellent performance on the basketball court frequently. In reality, like Michael Jordan, the majority of NBA players are black.² The glory of black players in the basketball is by no means a coincidence. In fact, as the song embodies the spirit of persistence and hope, the sport of basketball has played a critical role in constructing contemporary African Americans' culture. Focusing on them, although someone believes my passage is not politically correct, I will elaborate the enterprising spirit of African Americans via basketball.

Basketball, like American society, was racially segregated. The sport remained divided from 1904, when basketball was first introduced to African Americans on a wide scale, and ended until the racial integration of the National Basketball League in

¹ <https://www.songfacts.com/facts/r-kelly/i-believe-i-can-fly>

² Lapchick, Richard (August 25, 2021). "The 2021 Racial and Gender Report Card: National Basketball Association", p59

the 1940s and the National Basketball Association in 1950. The period in between became known as the Black Fives Era, and the term "fives" was used in reference to their five starting players in the early days of basketball which led to the term "Black Fives" to describe an all-Black team in the early 1900s.³ As the game continued to grow in the Black communities, not all of society was prepared for the growth. Segregation kept Black players from integrating with white clubs and Black teams were also prevented from playing in white-owned gymnasiums. Black Fives Era basketball games went beyond the sport itself and became meaningful social events.

The Harlem Rens, is widely credited with being the most successful team during the era. The Rens were the first all-Black professional team founded and it compiled a record of 2588-539 over its time, often playing interracial games that drew large crowds. Because of their on-court dominance, the Rens were invited to the first-ever World Professional Basketball Tournament held in 1938 in Chicago, and they went on to win the inaugural tournament beating the whites-only basketball league champion Oshkosh All-Stars in the final.⁴ The win Rens gained on the biggest basketball stage at that time confirmed to many that Black basketball was first-rate in opening the door for integration years down the line in the NBA. The NBA's embracing of Black athletes closed the book on the near-50-year history of sustained excellence of Black basketball.

Black Fives Era pioneered basketball in many ways all over the world and left a legacy we still feel today. The teams and players in that era created something from nothing, with no road map, despite many fears, doubts, and obstacles, and for little more than the love of the game. They kept climbing to higher levels of success in front of ever-growing audiences. In the meantime, they fostered hope, aspiration, pride, unity and self-esteem among African Americans in the most pivotal period in Black history, when those attributes were prerequisites for survival and success.

³ Johnson, Claude (2012). Black fives: the Alpha Physical Culture Club's pioneering African American basketball team, 1904-1923. Greenwich, Connecticut.

⁴ "The New York Renaissance Professional Black Basketball Team, 1920-1950" (PhD dissertation), by Susan J. Rayl (born 1956), Pennsylvania State University (1996), p65.

Basketball games are typically fierce, characterized by intense and confrontational competition between teams. To win the game, players not only need to spare no efforts during the match but are obligated to enhance their physical fitness and skills everyday so that they are capable of dominating the court.⁵ As a basketball enthusiast, I am really aware of the hardships behind bright success. Kobe Bryant, who achieved tremendous success in his professional basketball career, being regarded as one of the greatest players in NBA history, was asked by a reporter about why he was so successful, and Kobe responded " Have you seen Los Angeles at 4 am? " It is strict training that is the reason why he has unparalleled success. As far as the whole society is concerned, basketball is not just a platform for athletic prowess but has also become a symbol of resilience and identity.

The enterprising spirit in basketball is the external manifestation and it is closely tied to the American Dream. The American Dream is a profound concept in American society, representing the belief that individuals can achieve success and happiness through hard work and perseverance. This belief emphasizes equal opportunities for everyone to pursue their goals, free from the constraints of social background or race. The American Dream calls for everyone to strive towards prosperity through their own hard work, courage, creativity, and determination, and these propositions are certainly in concert with the notions of triumph, inspiration, fame in professional sports including basketball.⁶

Traditionally, it was assumed that Black people should not have a life as good as White people in discriminatory beliefs, and they seemed destined to be failures and disruptive elements in society. Some researches seemed to support this, such as higher crime rates among Black people compared to White people and lower levels of education.⁷ However, these cold statistics did not consider the actual circumstances. Long-standing racial issues in American society have absolutely limited the

⁵ Dai bin, Yi Lizhou, Peng Xingyun. On the cultivation of basketball consciousness in youth basketball teaching and training [J]. Sports world: Academic Edition, 2018 (3): 114-118.

⁶ REUBEN A. BUFORD MAY. Living Through the Hoop: High School Basketball, Race, and the American Dream [M]. New York: New York University Press, 2008.

⁷ Darling-Hammond L. Unequal opportunity: Race and education[J]. The Brookings Review, 1998.

development prospects of these minority communities.

In addition to seeking stable and wealthy lives, the African Americans highlight the more equal and respected lives in the American Dream from the perspective of individual and racial pursuance. As we all know, their emphasis on social status is based on the long history of racial discrimination in American society. Until 1868, the 14th Amendment to the United States Constitution granted citizenship rights to African Americans, they just obtained the legal right to "equality at birth." After that, the world witnessed numerous instances of racial conflicts, and the systemic issue of racism in society remained unresolved. Despite there are some improvements in the living and social conditions for the Black people, modern American society still presents restricted opportunities for them to realize their simple dream.⁸

As a widely participated activity, basketball has the ability to bring everyone in the Black community together, significantly enhancing community engagement. Culturally, basketball is closely intertwined with African Americans' street culture. Playing basketball is not just an activity but a kind of lifestyle like listening to hip-hop. Almost every member in the community wants to improve their social distinction by means of basketball. They express and shape their personalities, pursuing something their families don't possess. The connection through basketball has forged a united and powerful entity within the Black community, playing a remarkable role in their influential power of discourse in society.

Many communities in the lower and middle-class community of the United States, due to poor management, often become seedbed of crime including sexual offense, drug business and gang conflict. Unfortunately, many Black communities also fall within this range. Persisting in basketball entails physical exertion undoubtedly, it helps to keep everyone focused on their own work instead of crime.⁹ Even if the environment is so awful that it is easy for the young people here to be trapped in the

⁸ Armstrong J, Carlos Chavez F L, Jones J H, et al. "A Dream Deferred": How Discrimination Impacts the American Dream Achievement for African Americans[J]. *Journal of Black Studies*, 2019, 50(3): 227-250.

⁹ Hartmann D, Depro B. Rethinking sports-based community crime prevention: A preliminary analysis of the relationship between midnight basketball and urban crime rates[J]. *Journal of sport and social issues*, 2006, 30(2): 180-196.

mess, the basketball provides a brand-new path to change their fortune entirely. They redirect their focus on basketball and strive to train both physical and skills and separate from despicable matters. The following success reinforces their belief that they are able to alter their living conditions better ultimately.

Today, basketball has become a normal and specialized sport in the Black community. These passionate young people's hope holds water, and through basketball they indeed make a living even improve promote social stratification. Kobe Bryant, Allen Ezail Iverson and Michael Jordan are widely recognized superstars in the basketball world. Their successes primarily serve as a source of inspiration for the Black community in terms of symbolic significance.

In the period of a black basketball player's growth, he is likely to encounter discriminatory racial circumstances to some extent. On these scenes, Black players may find themselves fighting for the honor of both themselves and their entire race. Despite these troubles, players firmly believe that racial factors don't define athletic abilities and all races have the equal starting point in games, and what they are supposed to do is sticking up to train.¹⁰ Nowadays, intensive racial opposition and strong political correctness are pervading in the US society. Like cyberbullying, people waste a significant amount of effort to ridiculous and meaningless events that are not relevant to race at all but forget to do something practical. By contrast, almost all of the Black players concentrate on how to make self-improvement in sports, and they finally break up people's preconceived notions after proving their astonishing potential.

In summary, this proactive attitude towards fighting better life is not only an individual realization for Black people but also embodies the collective spirit of ambition within their community. Basketball is not just a sport, and it is a spiritual activity that has fundamentally changed the worldview, philosophy, and values for African Americans. It has made them individuals with a positive, optimistic, proactive, and never-give-up attitude towards life. In a supportive community environment, they

¹⁰ Gonçalves C E, e Silva M J C, Carvalho H M, et al. Why do they engage in such hard programs? The search for excellence in youth basketball[J]. Journal of sports science & medicine, 2011, 10(3): 458.

believe from an early age that through their relentless efforts, they can change their lives despite starting with a disadvantage. Even if not aiming for the legendary success often seen in the public, they have infused vitality into their lives. With an enterprising attitude, they bid farewell to internal strife, defying the predictions of those who discriminate against them.